Last Minute Courier – Game Script

Development version v0.8, November 8, 2026. Rules and core mechanics describe implemented behavior. Structure checked against lecture deck 3: slides 19-23 distinguish gameplay modes and shell screens; slide 55 asks for a non-technical rules script. Player timing and response remain measured acceptance tasks.

Background and goal

A campus film screening is about to begin. The courier carries the three things that make the evening possible: coffee for the audience, a lens for the projector, and the reel for the clocktower screening. A pocket device borrows seconds from marked machinery while the rest of the world keeps moving. The goal is to complete all three deliveries and open the cinema.

Learning goals

Learn moving and looking; physically jump over a low obstacle; recognize blue clock tags and learn that Q extends a useful gap in machinery movement. Then transfer the same time-control ability to boarding/riding lifts and judging a horizontal shuttle crossing. Alternative arcades and ramps let the player trade route length for precision; Borrower cells (+1 Q use each) sit mainly on the precise lines, so using an ability well funds the next one. A practice cell teaches what they are. No new input is introduced during a timed delivery.

Rules and modes

Three untimed opening cards explain the evening, the ability and the controls (drawn as key caps). A practice yard teaches the three actions. WASD moves, mouse looks, Space jumps, Q slows marked devices, E interacts, C recenters, H opens help, Esc pauses, and R asks whether to restart the current unfinished order.

Walking up to a desk opens its brief (E reopens it after it is closed). The brief lists the parcel, destination, time limit and Q uses; E again or Enter accepts, Esc or Back closes it. Only acceptance starts the order clock. Orders have 60, 150 and 160 seconds and 3, 4 and 5 uses of borrowed time. Each use slows blue devices to 0.25 speed for at most 3 seconds, followed by a 1.5-second recharge; the remaining uses are shown as a count and pips beside the Q key. Practice is unlimited. The courier and order clock do not slow. Pausing freezes gameplay; releasing Q while paused is resolved on resume.

A cart knocks the courier aside with a short stagger (no teleport); during the lens delivery each knock or fall also cracks the lens case a little, and the third knock fails that order. Falling into a pond or off a walkway returns the courier to the last grounded checkpoint with a short fade and an explanation ("Splash!", "You dropped off the walkway"). Hedges mark the edge of the campus. The current order remains active. Timeout or a cracked lens offers retry and route help. R asks before restarting only the unfinished order, its devices, uses and cells; earlier deliveries and stamps remain. Delivered and final states cannot be undone by R. Play Again starts a fresh run.

Scene and interaction sequence

1. Read the three cards, select an optional language, and practice in a safe yard with no delivery clock.

2. Accept coffee at the parcel desk. Cross cart traffic or use the arcade; jump or steer around planters. E delivers at the coffee stand and its warm light turns on.

3. Read and accept the lens at the same stand. Turn into the garden, use or bypass the first lift, cross the raised beds and stepping stones (or use the side route), then reach the projection booth via the second lift or ramp. The projector appears after delivery.

4. Read and accept the reel at the booth. Navigate traffic, ride or bypass a horizontal shuttle, ascend to the upper walk and negotiate planters. Follow the central cinema aisle, then turn left toward the roofless clocktower console and its orange square. The screening lights and landscape screen reveal; a cinema ticket shows three stamps and the run statistics.

Feedback and presentation

Menus are courier slips: a coloured header band, paper body, perforation and key-cap buttons. The in-play HUD uses compact dark plates in the corners: order and destination (top left), the delivery clock that turns red and pulses under 20 seconds plus a rotating compass arrow and distance (top centre), the Q key and charge meter that flashes red when Q is pressed without charge (bottom left), and a single contextual line with the E prompt (bottom centre). Lilita One sets display type and Nunito interface text; Chinese, Japanese and Korean use Noto Sans CJK. Failed actions have explicit messages and recovery. Each completed delivery changes the world, plays a stamp cue and preserves progress. Warm sunset, stationary soft clouds and distant hills support orientation. A 48-second original musical base gains synchronized strings after coffee and bells after the lens; all three layers and interaction sounds share the sound switch. English is the startup language; six optional languages are selected from one menu.

Comfort and accessibility

Adjust field of view and sensitivity; optionally lock camera direction; use C to aim toward the route. No camera shake, head bob, motion blur or automatic speed zoom. Reading never consumes the order budget. Pausing suspends play, retries preserve earlier work, and route alternatives reduce dependence on precise platform timing. Keyboard menu navigation is supported. Comfort, readability and full mouse interaction still require player verification.

Iteration and evidence

The user requested a stronger opening, less generic typography, a prettier sky, enjoyable sounds and a comfortable 3D view. Technical checks also found tutorial bypasses, invalid-height interactions, ramp lips, misleading side-route navigation, default-grid terrain and an unbuilt-lighting warning. Implementations and observed regressions are recorded in ITERATIONS.md and QA-Evidence.json. The user reported practice confusion and faint route markings on November 5. Those partial-session observations drove v0.5.3. A complete first-time run and measured 5-10 minute pacing remain required.

v0.5 moment–to–moment clarity

In practice, cross when the cart moves aside. Q is an optional tool for making the gap last longer. A safe crossing is accepted whether Q was held, released early, or never pressed. The lesson does not reset the courier for choosing natural timing. An actual cart hit still returns to a checkpoint, with an explicit collision message. Crossing saves forward progress.

One continuous orange line with broad arrows marks the single recommended route of the current task; side paths keep their signs but are not painted, so the line and the marker never disagree. Where the route continues on a lift or the shuttle, orange chevrons are painted on the platform and ride with it. A stationary orange ring and downward pointer mark the next waypoint; it follows a side path only once the courier is clearly on it. Future delivery markings are hidden. These guides have no collision. C gently recenters the view.

At a lift, wait for it to come down without spending Q, then hold Q and walk aboard (Space also works) while it rests at your level. Once aboard, release Q so it carries you normally. At the far landing, walk forward to step off. Contextual prompts follow these stages and remain visible while Q is active. A nearby delivery desk shows ARRIVED and E Deliver package. Reading the next brief has no timer; only Accept delivery starts it.

Coffee delivery places hot cups on the counter and starts the strings. The second delivery brings the audience into the terrace and starts the bells. The last delivery reveals the moonlit screen, three-stamp ticket and wider concluding view. These are implemented feedback; their emotional impact requires player observation.

Player, perspective and competition

The expected player uses a keyboard and mouse and may be unfamiliar with timing challenges or 3D camera control. The player controls one courier from a following third-person camera, with an avatar-based interaction model. The intended skills are observation, coordinated movement, landing judgment and deciding when to spend a short time-control window. There is one local single-player campaign. There are no opponents, multiplayer rules, leaderboards, difficulty levels or separate time-trial mode. Improving one's own delivery time is an optional personal goal, not another implemented mode.

Complete mode and transition reference

Mode or shell screen	Available decisions and actions	Clock and devices	Exit
Opening shell	Three story/control cards; continue/back; language; quit	No delivery timer; devices inactive	Continue after card three enters practice
Practice gameplay	Move, look, jump, hold/release Q (unlimited), C, pause/help	No delivery deadline; all carts and lifts run; a striped yard gate stays closed	Actual jump and safe cart-lane crossing with or without Q; reaching the parcel desk opens the first brief
Await-pickup gameplay	Walk back to the desk after closing its brief; pause/help	No delivery deadline; carts and lifts keep running; only the marker to the desk is shown	Stepping up to the desk or pressing E there reopens the brief
Briefing shell	Read parcel, destination, route and budget; E or Enter accepts; Esc/Back closes	No budget consumed	Accept enters delivery; cancel returns to pickup
Delivery gameplay (primary)	Move/look/jump/Q; E delivers; C; help/pause; R asks to restart the current order	Current budget and marked devices advance in real time, with selective Q slowdown	Valid E delivery, timeout, or pause
Pause/help shell	Resume; story/route help; sound, camera and language settings; retry when available; quit	Clock, devices, charge and recovery are frozen	Resume returns to the exact preceding gameplay state
Delivered shell	View outcome/stamp, 1-3 stars, the customer's measure (warmth, lens condition or time left) and cells collected; read next brief	Completed delivery fixed; next timer has not started	Read next opens next brief at the same counter
Timeout shell	Retry unfinished order; view route help	No ongoing delivery or device movement	Retry reopens that order's brief at its pickup
Completion shell	Read ticket, stars per stamp, total out of 9 and rank, delivery time and retries; Play Again	Three deliveries complete; ending animation plays	Play Again returns to opening and resets progress

Practice and delivery share the same avatar, camera and action vocabulary. Shell screens restrict world actions so reading and settings do not accidentally move the courier. Menu Tab selects controls; Space activates a focused toggle; Enter continues or accepts; sliders use Enter and arrows. A language change does not restart the order; the L shortcut works only on menu screens so it cannot fire mid-delivery. Progress is session-only: quitting does not save a campaign. Play Again preserves selected presentation preferences in the current process; a fresh launch defaults to English.

Operational rules and edge cases

• Move relative to camera direction. Space jumps from the ground; holding it does not provide flight. Orange markers identify routes/interaction areas; blue clock tags identify devices affected by Q. A physical alternative route does not require a separate unlock.

• Q affects blue carts and platforms, not the courier, scenery or order deadline. Each delivery grants a fixed number of uses (3, 4, 5); starting a slowdown spends one. A use lasts at most three seconds; releasing early ends it and starts a 1.5-second recharge. Pressing Q while recharging or with no uses left does nothing to the world but flashes the meter red, and an empty count also shows a message pointing to gaps and side paths. Retrying an order restores its uses. Holding through exhaustion does not automatically start another use: release and press again.

• On a moving platform, wait for it to reach the near landing, slow it if needed while boarding, release Q to travel at normal speed, and leave at the far landing. Holding Q throughout the ride makes travel slower. The longer side route trades travel time for easier geometry.

• E only reads or delivers within the marked area at a compatible height; standing underneath or far above a desk is invalid. An invalid E does not lose a parcel or advance an order. A reachable destination says ARRIVED and shows the delivery action.

• Coffee, lens and reel must be completed in that order. Accepting gives 60, 150 and 160 seconds respectively (v0.5.4; the earlier 140/170/200 allowed an expert run to finish with over two thirds of every clock unused). Reading a brief never starts its clock. Delivery succeeds when E is used at the destination before the order reaches zero. An expired order must be retried.

• A fall into water, off a raised walkway or out of the delivery's area returns the courier to a safe grounded checkpoint with a message naming the cause. Cart contact is a knock-back with a 0.7 s stagger and brief immunity, not a teleport. No stamp or parcel is removed.

• Carts, lifts and the shuttle run whenever the courier can move, including practice and waiting for a pickup; collisions count the same everywhere.

• Until the first order is accepted, a striped yard gate after the parcel desk is closed. Walking around it returns the courier to the desk with the message that the gate opens on acceptance.

• E never fails silently: away from a desk or destination it says where to go instead.

• People are solid, and large props stop the camera instead of letting it slide inside them; thin posts and floor markings do not.

• Carts are traffic: each lane has a depot shed at both ends and carts drive out of one, across the lane and into the other, one way. Q slows the cart's clock, so it waits in its depot longer.

• Borrower cells: 4, 5 and 6 on the three routes (one more in practice, which only teaches). Touching one gives Q one more use in the running order, plays a chime and flashes the Q key. Most sit on the harder line. Retrying an order restores its cells.

• Stars, judged by each customer's concern: coffee by warmth (time left / limit: at least 45% earns 3, at least 20% earns 2, otherwise 1); the lens by care (no knocks 3, one knock 2, two knocks 1; a third knock cracks it); the reel by time left before the screening (same thresholds as coffee). The ending totals them out of 9: 9 Legend of the Last Minute, 7-8 Star Courier, 4-6 Reliable Courier, otherwise Courier in Training.

• Feel: holding Q tints the screen cool blue with a vignette and lowers the music's pitch; a cart hit or fall flashes red with a thud; the last 10 seconds tick; deliveries burst into paper confetti.

• R (after confirmation) and the Retry control reset the current unfinished order to its pickup, including its deadline, device positions and Q allowance. Earlier completed orders, stamps, cups, audience and music progression remain. Retry is unavailable during untimed practice and does not undo delivered or completed states.

• The ending's delivery time is the sum of the three successful-order clocks. It excludes story reading, practice, pause, brief recovery and discarded attempts. The Retry counter counts explicit order restarts, not individual falls/cart recoveries. Neither statistic is a complete first-time wall-clock duration.

• There is no life limit, combat, inventory puzzle, hidden score threshold, random failure roll, currency, paid unlock or permanently lost progress within a running session. No special ending requires a fast time.

Ability teaching and later use

Ability	Initial demonstrated use	Later available transfer	Validation still needed
Move/look	Reach the practice marker with camera-relative WASD; recenter and mouse controls explained	Choose long arcades or short device routes, turn between landings and align with the final cinema aisle	First-time route comprehension without coaching
Jump	Actually jump over the low training step; simply walking around does not pass	Jump across the stepping stones on the recommended line and onto a planter for a cell; step off a raised lift; combine movement and landing judgment	A first-time player must demonstrate a later application; safe routes can bypass these challenges
Selective time control	Observe the cart gap; optionally try Q to prolong it. Safe natural timing is accepted	Slow a lift/shuttle for boarding, release it to travel, then judge disembarkation; ride the shuttle over water for its cell; ration 5 uses across 6 devices on the last route	Platform physics regression passes; ordinary simultaneous Q + movement input and independent human learning transfer still require testing

The level provides later applications of every taught ability, and the painted recommended line uses them: the lifts, the stepping stones, the cart lanes and the shuttle. Side paths remain for cautious players; Borrower cells on the harder line and the star rating give a concrete reason to take the applications instead.

Feedback–driven revisions

Ordinary keyboard checks in v0.5.1 led to a shorter coffee awning, open curb/rail junctions, safe side-ramp checkpoints and recovery guidance. v0.5.2 added staged platform instructions but also forced Q use at the training crossing. On November 5 the user reported that waiting for a natural gap was intuitive, yet crossing that way caused respawns; they also found the route unclear. v0.5.3 removes the forced-Q reset, distinguishes real collision recovery, saves crossing progress and adds continuous high-contrast route arrows plus a visible next-waypoint marker. On November 7 a real-speed autoplay that uses only player controls timed out twice at the final shuttle: a side-path guardrail fenced its boarding edge. v0.5.4 keeps rails off every platform footprint and the stepping-stone takeoff, adds a landing lip at the raised final lift, tightens the order budgets to 60/150/160 s after the expert run left most of each clock unused, and aligns two waypoints with painted corners. On November 8 the project owner's first uncoached playthrough of the packaged game found that the desk did not stop them, carts stood still before an order, E gave no response at the counter, and the camera could enter an NPC; they also asked for a visible Q count. v0.6 opens briefs on arrival, adds a yard gate until the first order, runs all devices continuously, explains every E press, gives people and props camera collision, and limits Q to a counted 3/4/5 uses per delivery. The owner then judged it still less fun than commercial games: v0.7 adds golden clocks on the risky lines, a 1-3 star rating per delivery with a total and rank, and audiovisual feel for Q, hits, the final seconds and deliveries. The owner then found it monotonous and often against common sense, and saw the orange line lead to a ramp while the marker led to a lift. v0.8 turns carts into one-way depot traffic, replaces teleporting hits with a knock-back, gives each parcel its own rule and stars (cooling coffee, a lens that cracks after three knocks, a reel racing the screening), turns golden clocks into Borrower cells (+1 Q use), adds hedges and named reset causes, explains each hand-over in the briefs, and paints only the recommended route with chevrons riding on the lifts.

Three engine regression suites pass, including safe crossings with no Q, early Q release, valid slowdown, real cart contact and route visibility/collision checks. An ordinary-keyboard technical check crossed the practice lane without Q and observed the next lesson with a full charge. These are partial technical checks and actual user-reported practice feedback. No complete human duration, enjoyment, comfort or later learning-transfer result has been recorded. Full observations and commit-linked changes are in ITERATIONS.md, PlaytestFeedback-Nov05.zh.md and QA-Evidence.json.

Graduate Mechanics and Balance Analysis

Last Minute Courier | v0.8 | November 8, 2026

Required for this student's graduate submission. Based on lecture deck 4, The Art of Game Design: mechanics 1-7 and the balance lenses on slides 104, 112 and 118. The following answers refer to implemented rules. November 5 practice feedback is recorded explicitly; other player-feeling claims remain hypotheses.

Seven mechanic categories

Course mechanic	Implemented model and example	What the player decides
1. Space	A continuous, bounded 3D campus with ground, raised landings, ramps, gaps and connected routes. Desks and delivery zones are meaningful subspaces. Height matters: E from beneath a desk is invalid.	Choose a connected route, align with a landing, and reach the correct interaction area.
2. Time	Continuous movement; separate 60/150/160-second order clocks; Q slows blue-tagged machinery to 0.25 speed for up to three real seconds per use, with 3/4/5 uses per delivery and a 1.5-second recharge between uses. Reading is untimed; pause suspends simulation.	Spend the window after observing a gap; release Q after boarding; balance longer safe travel against a deadline.
3. Objects, attributes and states	Courier: position, grounded/jumping/recovering, held parcel. Cart: lane position and time phase. Platform: location and boarding/riding state. Order: unread, accepted, delivered or expired. Borrower: ready, active or recharging, with uses left. Borrower cell: available or collected. Lens case: knocks taken. Desks, stamps, stars and the cinema have persistent delivered states within a run.	Read visible cart/platform motion, charge bar, delivery count and clock to choose the next action.
4. Actions	Basic actions: move, look, jump, hold/release Q and interact. Strategic actions: wait for a gap, preserve a charge for boarding, release it during travel, choose a bypass, or retry an order after learning its route.	Combine a small set of verbs in different sequences. Settings and help are shell actions, not additional courier powers.
5. Rules	Three ordered parcels, reachable-height interaction, a fixed number of Q uses per delivery (the last route has six devices but five uses), grounded checkpoints, order-specific timeouts and retries, and a three-delivery completion condition. The game enforces these rules; the script states their consequences.	Complete the current goal within its budget, recover from a mistake, and understand which progress persists.
6. Skill	Physical: coordinate camera-relative movement, jumping and landings. Mental: observe periodic machinery, estimate a safe interval and compare routes. No social opponent or avatar-stat upgrade system is required.	Improve real observation and coordination through practice rather than buying numerical power.
7. Chance	Gameplay-critical traffic and platform movement are periodic, not random success rolls. Arrival timing can feel uncertain to a novice; motion can be observed and learned. Cosmetic variation does not decide whether a delivery succeeds.	Take an informed timing risk or choose a longer route; failure is not assigned by a dice roll.

These categories describe different aspects of the same interaction. For example, slowing a lift combines time, a platform's changing attributes, player action, limited-charge rules, 3D landing space and player skill. Its success is not a random probability check.

Balance lens 1: Reward (deck 4, slide 104)

1. What rewards exist, and what other forms are possible? Each successful delivery gives a visible stamp, a confetti burst, a short sound and a persistent world change. Coffee adds cups/steam and strings; the lens prepares the projector, audience and bells; the reel reveals the screen and combines the stamps into a cinema ticket. Skill rewards since v0.7/v0.8: Borrower cells (+1 Q use each, mostly on the harder lines) and a 1-3 star rating per delivery by what that customer cares about (coffee warmth, lens condition, time before the screening), totalled out of 9 with a rank on the ticket. A cosmetic shop is not needed for this short cooperative story.

2. Are rewards exciting or boring, and why? The design hypothesis is that an inhabited scene and a seat at the event make the task feel consequential. Automated checks can verify that objects, result text and music-layer state change; it cannot establish excitement. Ask first-time players what changed after each delivery and which moment they cared about, recording contrary responses as well.

3. Do players understand the reward? A completion count, named parcel stamp, written outcome and changed destination communicate the same event through several channels. The final card explains that three stamps form one admission ticket. Comprehension remains a playtest criterion: the tester should explain why the ticket appears without coaching.

4. Is the reward too regular, and should timing vary? Three major rewards are deliberately predictable because there are exactly three concrete deliveries; Borrower cells add small, frequent rewards between them, placed where the player has to time a cart, ride a lift or shuttle, or jump to a planter or stepping stone. Their intervals and presentation differ with the route and parcel. Random reward schedules would obscure the causal link between helping and the scene changing. Whether a route's interval feels too long must be measured, not assumed.

5. How are rewards connected? They are preparation for one film night: audience comfort, projection capability and film content. The same delivery stamps become the final ticket, and musical layers accumulate rather than replacing unrelated tracks. This connection is part of both the implemented world and the opening story.

6. Does the reward build too quickly or slowly? The sequence grows from a local coffee response to a populated terrace and then the screening. The Nov 7 real-speed autoplay (ordinary player verbs, no teleporting) reached the ending in 3:00 wall time using 12.3 / 62.8 / 63.0 s of order clock. It knows every crossing in advance, so this is an expert lower bound and is insufficient to establish reward pacing for first-time humans. Record each delivery's wall time and response before changing route length. The star rating gives a finished run a reason to be replayed: the expert autoplay earns 9/9, while a first-time run that avoids every risk typically earns fewer.

Balance lens 2: Punishment (deck 4, slide 112)

1. What punishments exist? Cart contact knocks the courier aside with a short stagger; falling into water or off a walkway returns to a grounded checkpoint. On the lens delivery each knock or fall cracks the case a little (fewer stars), and the third fails that order. Timeout requires retrying the unfinished order. An explicit retry discards that order's attempt, restores its clock and resets its devices/charge. Earlier parcels and world changes survive. There is no finite life pool, harsh score penalty or full-campaign reset after one error.

2. Why punish, and what should it achieve? A visible setback gives traffic timing and safe landings a consequence. Retrying a single order gives the player a chance to apply newly learned timing without replaying already mastered routes. The purpose is attention and learning, not humiliation or lengthening play through repeated work.

3. Does the punishment feel fair, and why or why not? The November 5 user reported that their intuitive strategy was to wait for the cart to move aside and cross quickly, but the forced-Q lesson respawned them. That was a mismatch between the visible danger and the actual failure rule. v0.5.3 accepts safe timing with or without Q and names an actual cart hit in its recovery message. Earlier side-ramp checkpoints still limit lost progress. Engine checks cover both safe passage and real contact; the player's response to the new build is not yet known.

4. Could a reward produce the same or better effect? Safe progress is already rewarded by new checkpoints and preserved delivery stamps. The game avoids subtracting delivered stamps or adding an arbitrary time penalty. A cleaner crossing naturally leaves more deadline time, without an extra score system. Removing every setback would make machinery less meaningful; the current compromise keeps the local challenge and limits repeated work.

5. Are strong penalties matched by strong rewards? The strongest current setback is replaying one order, not the whole campaign. Its reward is a persistent contribution to the screening, with the final parcel opening the event. Budgets were tightened in v0.5.4 from 140/170/200 to 60/150/160 s, about 2.5-5x the expert autoplay time, so the deadline matters without demanding mastery. Whether the budgets and repetition are proportionate for a first-time player is still a test question. Do not justify a frustrating timeout solely by saying the ending is a reward.

Balance lens 3: Simplicity and complexity (deck 4, slide 118)

1. What innate complexity exists? Players must know the blue-tag rule, three-second allowance, the per-delivery use count shown beside the Q key, the difference between reading and accepting, the delivery order and the difference between checkpoint recovery and retry. These rules are explained in cards, practice, contextual hints, the brief and pause help. Seven language options share the same rules.

2. Can innate complexity become emergent complexity? One Q rule is used on carts, vertical lifts and a horizontal shuttle. There is no separate freeze power, vehicle control scheme or per-device recharge rule. Observing and combining that one rule with movement creates the later decisions. Directly opening the next untimed brief removes an unnecessary extra interaction.

3. What emergent interactions arise? Slowing a cart extends a crossing window but still spends real order time; slowing a lift helps boarding but delays travel if held; a longer ramp avoids precision but costs travel time. Releasing Q can therefore be strategically useful. These interactions are implemented; whether novices independently discover them must be observed.

4. Is anything too simple? Optional bypasses can still let a player finish without transferring Q or jumping to a later device. Forcing Q during an otherwise safe crossing caused documented user confusion, so v0.5.3 teaches it as a useful choice and retains explicit lift boarding/release guidance. The user also found the route unclear; larger arrows, current-order highlighting and a visible next waypoint reduce navigation ambiguity. Later independent ability use and the clarity of the revised route still require observation.

Evidence and submission relationship

GameScript.md states the complete player-facing rules and modes. ITERATIONS.md and QA-Evidence.json distinguish ordinary-input checks, controlled physics tests and actual human feedback. Human playtests are currently zero. This analysis does not convert a design hypothesis into a tested finding; the final report must add observed player evidence and the corresponding revision commits.